Speech Prepared by Dr. B.R. Ambedkar for the 1936 Annual Conference of Jat-Pat-Todak Mandal of Lahore

About Dr. B.R. Ambedkar



Dr. Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar (1891–1956), popularly known as Babasaheb Ambedkar, was one of modern India's greatest intellectuals, social reformers, jurists, economists, and political leaders. Born into the socially marginalised Mahar community, he experienced caste discrimination from an early age, which inspired his lifelong struggle for equality and justice. He received higher education at prestigious institutions such as Columbia University and the London School of Economics, where he developed his expertise in law, economics, and political science. As the principal architect of the Constitution of India, Ambedkar championed the values of liberty, equality, and fraternity. Through influential works such as *Annihilation of Caste* and *The Problem of the Rupee*, he challenged caste oppression and advocated for the rights of Dalits, leaving a lasting legacy in India's social, political, and intellectual history.

About the Speech for the Jat-Pat-Todak Mandal

The prescribed text is an excerpt from a speech that Dr. B.R. Ambedkar prepared for the 1936 Annual Conference of the **Jat-Pat-Todak Mandal**, an anti-caste reform organisation founded in Lahore in 1922 as part of the Arya Samaj movement. Invited to preside over the conference, Ambedkar wrote a bold address that argued not merely for caste reform but for the complete annihilation of the caste system and its religious foundations. The organisers considered some of his views too controversial and requested that he revise the speech. Ambedkar refused to alter his arguments, leading to the cancellation of the conference. He later published the undelivered speech as *Annihilation of Caste*, now regarded as one of the most influential critiques of caste and social inequality in modern India.

Text

It is a pity that Caste even today has its defenders. The defenses are many. It is defended on the ground that the Caste System is but another name for division of labor and if division of labor is a necessary feature of every civilized society then it is argued that there is nothing wrong in the Caste System. Now the first thing to be urged against this view is that Caste System is not mere division of labor. It is also a division of laborers. Civilized society undoubtedly needs division of labor.

But in no civilized society is division of labor accompanied by this unnatural division of laborers into watertight compartments. The Caste System is not merely a division of laborers which is quite different from division of labor it is a hierarchy in which the divisions of laborers are graded one above the other. In no other country is the division of labor accompanied by this gradation of laborers. There is also a third point of criticism against this view of the Caste System. This division of labor is not spontaneous; it is not based on natural aptitudes. Social and individual efficiency requires us to develop the capacity of an individual to the point of competency to choose and to make his own career. This principle is violated in the Caste System in so far as it involves an attempt to appoint tasks to individuals in advance, selected not on the basis of trained original capacities, but on that of the social status of the parents. Looked at this from another point of view - this stratification of occupations which is the result of the Caste System is positively pernicious. Industry is never static. It undergoes rapid and abrupt changes. With such changes an individual must be free to change his occupation. Without such freedom to adjust himself to changing circumstances it would be impossible for him to gain his livelihood. Now the Caste System will not allow Hindus to take to occupations where they are wanted if they do not belong to them by heredity. If a Hindu is seen to starve rather than take to new occupations not assigned to his Caste, the reason is to be found in the Caste System. By not permitting readjustment of occupations, caste becomes a direct cause of much of the unemployment we see in the country. As a form of division of labor, the Caste system suffers from another serious defect. The division of labor brought about by the Caste System is not a division based on choice. Individual sentiment, individual preference has no place in it. It is based on the dogma of predestination. Considerations of social efficiency would compel us to recognize that the greatest evil in the industrial system is not: so much poverty and the suffering that it involves as the fact that so many persons have callings which make no appeal to those who are engaged in them. Such callings constantly provoke one to aversion, ill will and the desire to evade. There are many occupations in India which on account of the fact that they are regarded as degraded by the Hindus

provoke those who are engaged in them to aversion. There is a constant desire to evade and escape from such occupations which arises solely because of the blighting effect which they produce upon those who follow them owing to the slight and stigma cast upon them by the Hindu religion. What efficiency can there be in a system under which neither men's hearts nor their minds are in their work? As an economic organization Caste is therefore a harmful institution, in as much as, it involves the subordination of man's natural powers and inclinations to the exigencies of social rules

Summary of the Speech

Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's speech, prepared for the 1936 Annual Conference of the Jat-Pat-Todak Mandal of Lahore, presents a powerful critique of the caste system and challenges the common arguments made in its defence. The selected excerpt focuses primarily on the economic and social consequences of caste, exposing its harmful effects on individuals as well as on society.

Ambedkar begins by rejecting the claim that the caste system is merely another form of the "division of labour." While every civilized society requires a division of labour, he argues that caste is fundamentally different because it is also "a division of labourers." Unlike a functional distribution of work based on ability or necessity, the caste system separates people into rigid and unequal groups. He observes that caste creates "watertight compartments" and establishes "a hierarchy in which the divisions of labourers are graded one above the other." Thus, caste is not simply an economic arrangement but a system of social inequality that ranks human beings according to birth rather than merit.

Ambedkar further argues that the caste system ignores the natural talents and interests of individuals. Instead of allowing people to develop their abilities and choose careers freely, it assigns occupations on the basis of hereditary status. Such a system, he contends, violates the principle that every individual should have the opportunity to cultivate their capacities and pursue a profession according to their competence. By determining occupations through birth, caste suppresses individual freedom and social efficiency.

The speech also highlights the economic disadvantages of hereditary occupations. Since industries and occupations constantly change, individuals must be free to adapt to new circumstances. However, the caste system prevents people from entering occupations outside their traditional caste. Ambedkar points out that many Hindus would rather remain unemployed or even starve than take up work considered inappropriate for their caste.

Consequently, caste contributes directly to unemployment and obstructs economic progress by restricting occupational mobility.

Another major criticism concerns the psychological effects of caste-based occupations. Because certain professions are regarded as degrading, those forced into them experience shame, resentment, and a constant desire to escape. Ambedkar notes that such occupations "make no appeal to those who are engaged in them" and therefore produce "aversion, ill will and the desire to evade." When workers neither value nor identify with their work, productivity and efficiency inevitably suffer.

Ambedkar concludes that the caste system is not only socially unjust but also economically harmful. By subordinating "man's natural powers and inclinations to the exigencies of social rules," it destroys individual freedom, reduces efficiency, and hinders national development. He therefore presents caste as a fundamentally oppressive institution that must be dismantled for a just and progressive society.

Important Themes of the Speech

1. Caste as a Division of Labourers

The central argument of the speech is Ambedkar's distinction between the **division of labour** and the **division of labourers**. He argues that while division of labour is necessary for an organized society, caste permanently divides people into hereditary social groups and ranks them unequally. As he famously states, **"Caste System is not mere division of labor. It is also a division of laborers."** This distinction exposes caste as a system of social discrimination rather than an efficient economic arrangement.

2. Inequality and Social Hierarchy

Ambedkar demonstrates that caste is built upon hierarchy. Instead of treating occupations as equally valuable, it places some communities above others. This graded inequality creates permanent privilege for some and lifelong discrimination for others, making social equality impossible. His observation that caste creates **"watertight compartments"** reflects its rigid and exclusionary nature.

3. Denial of Individual Freedom

Another important theme is the denial of personal liberty. The caste system assigns occupations according to birth instead of talent or choice. Ambedkar insists that every

individual should have the opportunity to develop their abilities and choose a profession freely. Hereditary occupations deny human potential and prevent people from realizing their capabilities.

4. Economic Inefficiency

Ambedkar argues that caste weakens the economy because it prevents occupational mobility. In a changing industrial society, people must be able to move from one profession to another. By restricting such movement, caste contributes to unemployment and reduces productivity. This makes caste not merely a moral problem but also an economic obstacle to national progress.

5. Human Dignity and the Psychology of Labour

The speech also examines the emotional consequences of caste. Occupations labelled as "low" or "degrading" generate feelings of humiliation and dissatisfaction among workers. Ambedkar asks, **"What efficiency can there be in a system under which neither men's hearts nor their minds are in their work?"** This rhetorical question emphasizes that meaningful work requires dignity, respect, and personal fulfilment.

6. Social Reform and Justice

Underlying the entire speech is Ambedkar's vision of a society based on equality, freedom, and justice. His critique of caste is ultimately a call for social transformation. He argues that any system which suppresses natural talent, denies equal opportunities, and imposes inherited inequality cannot contribute to a modern democratic society. The speech therefore remains a foundational text in the struggle against caste discrimination and for social justice.

Multiple Choice Questions

1. According to Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, the caste system is not merely a division of labour because it is also a:

a) Division of wealth
b) Division of religion
c) Division of labourers
d) Division of language

2. Why does Ambedkar criticise the caste system's method of assigning occupations?

a) It encourages competition among workers.
b) It is based on the social status of one's parents rather than individual ability.
c) It allows people to choose their professions freely.
d) It increases industrial productivity.

3. According to the speech, what does the caste system prevent individuals from doing?

a) Receiving higher education
b) Participating in politics
c) Changing occupations according to changing circumstances
d) Owning property

4. Ambedkar argues that the caste system contributes to unemployment because it:

a) Discourages industrial development.
b) Prevents people from taking occupations outside their hereditary caste.
c) Promotes excessive competition.
d) Encourages migration to cities.

5. According to Ambedkar, many occupations in India provoke "aversion" among workers because they are:

a) Poorly paid.
b) Difficult to perform.
c) Considered degrading and carry social stigma.
d) Located in rural areas.

6. What is Ambedkar's final assessment of the caste system as an economic organisation?

a) It is beneficial because it preserves traditional occupations.
b) It is necessary for maintaining social order.
c) It is harmful because it suppresses people's natural abilities and interests.
d) It is suitable only for agricultural societies.

Answer keys: 1. C; 2. B; 3. C; 4. B; 5. C; 6. C.

Short Answer Questions

1. What does Dr. B.R. Ambedkar mean when he says that the caste system is "not merely a division of labour, but also a division of labourers"?
Answer Hint: Ambedkar explains that while division of labour is necessary in society, the caste system divides people into rigid, hereditary groups and ranks them unequally, creating social hierarchy instead of equality.

2. Why does Ambedkar argue that the caste system is harmful to economic progress?
Answer Hint: The caste system assigns occupations by birth rather than ability, prevents people from changing professions according to changing circumstances, and contributes to unemployment and inefficiency.

3. How does the caste system affect the dignity and motivation of workers, according to Ambedkar?
Answer Hint: Many occupations are considered degrading because of caste prejudice, causing workers to feel shame, resentment, and dissatisfaction, which reduces their interest and efficiency in their work.

4. Why does Ambedkar believe that occupations should be based on individual aptitude rather than hereditary status?
Answer Hint: He argues that every individual should have the freedom to develop their talents and choose a career according to their abilities and interests. Occupations based on birth suppress human potential and violate the principles of social justice and individual freedom.

Essay Questions

1. Explain Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's critique of the caste system as presented in the prescribed excerpt. How does he distinguish between the "division of labour" and the "division of labourers"?

Answer Hint:
Explain Ambedkar's argument that the caste system is not merely a functional division of

work but a hereditary division of people into unequal social groups. Discuss how caste creates hierarchy, restricts individual freedom, assigns occupations by birth rather than merit, and undermines equality, justice, and social progress.

2. Discuss the economic and social consequences of the caste system according to Dr. B.R. Ambedkar. Why does he consider it harmful to both individuals and society?

Answer Hint:
Discuss how the caste system prevents occupational mobility, causes unemployment, ignores individual aptitude, and reduces economic efficiency. Explain its psychological effects by showing how caste-based occupations create stigma, dissatisfaction, and lack of motivation among workers. Conclude by explaining Ambedkar's view that the caste system suppresses human potential and hinders the development of a just and progressive society.